The Grand Accident

On climate change, societal acceleration, and the shipwrecks we've built in.

On 29 June 2021, the village of Lytton in British Columbia recorded 49.6 °C, breaking Canada's previous all-time heat record by 4.6 degrees. The next day, 90% of the village burned to the ground, killing two people; across the province that summer, wildfires would displace nearly 33,000. The heat itself, meanwhile, killed another 619 people across British Columbia, most of them elderly, many alone in their homes. Globally, disasters triggered 45.8 million new displacements in 2024, the highest annual figure since records began.

History has treated such disasters as acts of God, occurrences beyond human control. But disasters happen where natural forces meet the human fabric. When we build on the waterfront, we become vulnerable to floods. Gilbert White saw this when he wrote that ‘’floods are acts of God and flood losses are largely acts of man’’.

White's line is blurring. The *natural* side of natural disasters is becoming human too. Floods are less acts of God, more accidents of an accelerating society.

The natural selection of accidents

Paul Virilio described the inevitability of societal acceleration. Firms that produce faster outcompete slower rivals. States that mobilise faster win wars. Researchers who publish faster get the next contract. The result is a kind of natural selection where the accelerating actor survives.

But the natural selection of acceleration is also the natural selection of accidents. “When you invent the ship, you also invent the shipwreck,” Virilio wrote. Every technology arrives with its own negation, pre-installed. And the bigger the system, the bigger the wreck. A virus boards a plane in Wuhan and reaches every continent in ninety days. A glitch in algorithmic trading erases a trillion dollars in thirty-six minutes. A single botched software update grounds flights, freezes hospitals, and halts banks worldwide in a morning. As states, companies, and individuals accelerate, so does the severity of the accidents they produce.

The weather is a shipwreck

Acceleration needs fuel, and for a century we have burned it: coal, oil, and gas. The by-product, CO_2, has been collecting in the atmosphere like heat trapped under glass. A warmer atmosphere holds exponentially more water, intensifying both downpours and droughts. Warmer oceans store more heat and exhale more moisture, feeding heavier rainfall and stronger storms.

On 29 October 2024, 491 millimetres of rain fell on the Valencian town of Chiva in eight hours, a year's worth of water in a single afternoon. Attribution studies showed the storm was about 12% more intense and roughly twice as likely as it would have been in a cooler climate. 237 people died. Tens of thousands more were left to the slower aftermath that follows a flash flood: ruined homes, lost livelihoods, and the damaged mental life that follows.

The weather itself has become the accident. Climate change is the grand accident, the precondition for a million shipwrecks: floods, heatwaves, crop failures, mass extinctions, rising seas.

Why we can't brake

If speed is the problem, why can't we slow down? Because the same natural selection that produces the accidents protects the accident-producers. Fossil energy built the industries, infrastructures, and state revenues of the modern world, and the actors who depend on it have every reason, and every means, to delay, dilute, or obstruct change.

Climate change has been on the political agenda for decades. Environmental movements forced it there. Nearly every country has a climate ministry. The UN has convened annual climate summits since 1995. And yet, in 2024, energy-related CO_2 emissions reached an all-time high of 37.8 gigatonnes. COP28, the summit tasked with saving the climate, was hosted by a petrostate, the UAE, and attended by 2,456 fossil fuel lobbyists, more than the delegations of the ten most climate-vulnerable nations combined.

The problem of slowing down also shows in the emergence of a new super accelerator: AI. Training frontier AI models and running the data centres that host them demands electricity at an unprecedented scale, and China and the United States treat the race as existential. The logic is that whoever builds the most capable systems first will dominate the military and economic order of the century. No government in that position chooses to slow down. The cost is again the climate as data centers and AI centres demand energy.

No captain goes down

Maritime tradition gave us the figure of the captain who leaves last. He stays on the bridge until every passenger and crewman is safely off, and he goes down with the ship if he must. It is one of the older duties.

Ours don't.

Mark Zuckerberg is building a 5,000-square-foot underground bunker beneath a $270 million Hawaiian compound with its own food and energy supplies. Peter Thiel has spent a decade planning a bunker-compound on the shores of Lake Wanaka in New Zealand. LinkedIn co-founder Reid Hoffman has estimated that more than half of Silicon Valley billionaires have lined up their own 'apocalypse insurance.' The captains of the accelerator are quietly building lifeboats, and the lifeboats are for themselves.

Everyone else stays on deck. The flood comes for the low-lying neighbourhoods first, for the uninsured houses, for the elderly alone in flats without air conditioning, for the outdoor workers who cannot clock off in a heatwave. Wealth rides high; poverty is in the hold.

The great injustice is that those who contributed least to the wreck are paying the highest price.

When Pakistan's 2022 monsoon season delivered several times the usual rainfall to the Indus basin, floodwaters submerged a third of the country and affected 33 million people, displacing around 8 million. Pakistan's share of historical global greenhouse gas emissions is less than 1%. The water receded; the harm did not. Malaria cases quadrupled that year, from roughly 400,000 to more than 1.6 million, the worst outbreak since 1973.

In September 2023, Storm Daniel dropped up to 400 millimetres of rain on the Libyan city of Derna in a single day. Two aging dams above the city, neglected through years of political turmoil, failed. The resulting surge destroyed roughly a quarter of Derna and killed more than 11,000 people. Attribution analysis found that climate change made the rainfall around 50% more likely. Libya's share of global emissions is a rounding error.

Living inside the accident

We cannot assume the acceleration will stop. Some people are still working to slow the ship, and I hope they succeed. But even on the most optimistic mitigation trajectories, increasing damage from extreme weather will follow.

Adaptation is the other half of the work, and it is where a great deal of the interesting intellectual terrain now lies. How do you redesign a city so that a heatwave does not become a mass casualty event? How do you build early warning systems that actually reach the people who need them, in the languages they speak? How do you keep the slow, second wave of harm (the PTSD, the chronic disease, the communities that never quite recover after the water goes down) from doing more damage than the disaster itself? These are central questions with far reaching consequences for vitality, health, and well-being. And this is why I recently started a postdoc on urban climate adaptation for extreme weather.